

Chapter 11

Uninflectedness as a rule in Polish, an inflected language

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The chapter describes uninflected nouns referring to women in Polish. The absence of inflection on these nouns results from the lack of an inflectional paradigm that would suit the class in terms of both morphonology and semantics. In this case, uninflectedness, generally very peculiar in the language, has developed into a signal of feminine gender in its own right and given rise to a productive grammatical pattern. The lack of marking allows distinguishing the feminine words and the normally inflecting masculine counterparts. The text presents the functioning of the class that so poorly fits the Polish system, heavily reliant on inflection, competing patterns that do not involve uninflectedness as well as constraints on the use of the uninflected words. The last section gives a brief historical overview of the emergence of the category and shows that the process happened twice: first for surnames, then for personal common nouns. The article also addresses the ongoing debate among native speakers and recent developments which could potentially trigger the downfall of the discussed uninflected pattern.

1 Introduction

Polish is a language with rich inflection, involving nouns, pronouns, determiners, adjectives, participles, numerals and verbs. Yet, there are nouns (1% of all, cf. Stefańczyk 2007: 159) where the expected marking is lacking. This paper focuses on one type of uninflected nouns in Polish, originally masculine words used to refer to women (called U-FORMS here, cf. Section 3.1). Their uninflectedness, otherwise exceptional in the language, is essentially regular. Most of the words in question are borrowings, but we also find native ones in this group. Let us add that the



said nouns are originally regularly inflecting words referring to men and having the masculine grammatical gender.¹

The paper describes how this class of words functions in a language whose grammatical system it seems to fit so poorly, esp. considering the existence of rival morphological patterns. We will also sketch the historical development of U-forms, an open category at odds with basic Polish grammar, a regular pattern that as a whole is an exception.

Some aspects of the topic are socially very salient and constitute the subject of an ongoing public debate among native speakers. However, the bone of contention is not the uninflectedness of U-forms. It is the rival inflectable forms referring to women (which we call D-FORMS) whose increasingly common use (for the very same concepts) is controversial. U-forms surface in the debate, but as a peripheral issue. The roles are reversed here; our focus is on U-forms as a particularly interesting case of uninflectedness and the hotly debated D-forms are merely a point of reference. Thus, the paper is not meant to be a voice in the current debate in Poland; the aim is to analyse the usage without taking sides. We refer to the debate because it is a relevant part of the sociolinguistic reality.

Many examples come from the National Corpus of Polish (NKJP, Przepiórkowski et al. 2012), but the paper lacks an overall statistical analysis of the phenomena described. This is due to space limitations and particular difficulties with such a task. The tagging in the NKJP (or any corpus of Polish) logically relies on inflectional categories, which does not allow extracting reliable results for whole classes of uninflected nouns. However, the expressions referring to frequency used here are not mere opinions or guesses. First of all, they reflect the relative difficulty in finding examples. Furthermore, to compensate for the lack of the overall statistics, numbers for selected example phrases are included to support the points made at several points in the discussion. The related queries in the corpus were performed with the use of the PELCRA search engine (Pęzik 2012).

Section 2 of the paper briefly presents the Polish noun declension, then moves to factors conducive to uninflectedness of nouns. Section 3 is an analysis of the functioning of the uninflected words for women in the language at present

¹Polish is said to have five gender categories: masculine personal (virile), masculine animate/animal, masculine inanimate, feminine and neuter. The plain label “masculine” will still appear in the paper. With words referring to people it means masculine personal. The three masculine genders are also syncretised in a number of grammatical positions. Let us stress that there is no grammatical context in Polish that would distinguish as many as five gender values. The five-way division proposed by Mańczak (1956) results from the superposition of the maximal distinctions made in the accusative singular and plural.

(21st century). Section 4 provides a historical overview of the development of uninflected and inflectable words for women, including current changes.

2 Declension and lack thereof

2.1 Declension in Polish

This section is meant to present Polish declension without delving into detail. For a comprehensive picture the readers are referred to grammars (Zagorska-Brooks 1975, Laskowski 1979, Bielec 1998, Swan 2002). Let us start with an example of declension in use. (1) is the opening sentence of the preface to one academic grammar of Polish, for clarity divided into clauses here.

- (1) a. Książk-a t-a powstała na zamówieni-e.
 book-NOM.SG this-NOM.SG.F arise.PST.F PREP commission-ACC.SG
 ‘This book was commissioned.’
 b. Nie odmawia się Wydawnictw-u,
 NEG refuse.3SG IMPERS publishing_house-DAT.SG
 ‘One does not refuse a publishing house,’
 c. w któr-ym druk-Ø jest dla autor-a
 in which-LOC.SG.N print-NOM.SG be.3SG for author-GEN.SG
 honor-em.
 honour-INS.SG
 ‘to publish with which it is an honour for the author.’

(Nagórko 1997: 9)

(1) features a fairly representative selection of noun forms. We have a typical masculine nominative with a zero suffix, *druk* in (1c), a typical feminine one with the suffix *-a*, *książka* in (1a), a neuter accusative identical in form with the nominative, *zamówienie* in (1a), with a non-zero marker *-e*. There are distinct oblique case forms: a dative, *wydawnictwu* in (1b) and an instrumental, *honorem* in (1c), as well as a masculine personal genitive identical to the accusative, *autora* in (1c). The locative is exemplified by the relative pronoun *którym* in (1c). In sum, all Polish cases appear in (1), except the vocative, which is unlikely in academic prose. However, at the beginning of a preface one could easily imagine one of the vocative phrases in (2) preceding (1).

- (2) a. drog-i Czytelnik-u
 dear-VOC.SG.M reader-VOC.SG
 ‘dear Reader’

- b. *drodz-y* *Czytelnic-y*
 dear-VOC.PL.VIR reader-VOC.PL
 ‘dear Readers’
- c. *drogi-e* *Czytelnicz-k-i*, *drodz-y* *Czytelnic-y*
 dear-VOC.PL.NVIR reader-F-VOC.PL dear-VOC.PL.VIR reader-VOC.PL
 ‘dear Readers [female], dear Readers [male]’

As for syntactic relations, the nominative forms in (1) are subjects of the clauses, the instrumental marks the subject complement after a copula, the accusative is governed by the preposition *na*, etc. Case marking fulfils the grammatical requirements of the words the nouns are structurally connected with. This phenomenon, syntactic government (in the traditional sense, cf. Matthews 1981: 246–250), relies on the category of case and is essential for signalling clause structure. Case (as well as number and gender) is also marked on words modifying nouns, as in the demonstrative *ta* in (1a) and the adjectives in (2). This kind of agreement is crucial for the cohesion of noun phrases. Agreement can also be seen on the verb *powstała* in (1a), which shows the number as well as gender of the subject of the clause. Gender is only marked on verb forms based on the past tense, historically a participle.

Polish nouns inflect for 7 cases and 2 numbers. This yields a 14-slot system, but because of case syncretism, mostly systematic, as in (1–2), no noun has more than eleven distinct forms and many have fewer. Adjectives, participles and determiners show the case and number of the noun they modify and additionally mark its gender, an inherent property of a given noun. The declension markers are solely suffixes, although inflection may be accompanied by sound alternations in the stem, most of them predictable, cf. the forms in (2). The suffixes are fusional; it is never possible to separate the marking of case and number (and gender in noun modifiers). Nouns fall into a number of declension classes which have different sets of markers for specific grammatical values. If this general description is reminiscent of classical Indo-European languages such as Latin or Sanskrit, the association is correct – the overall makeup of the Polish declension system is conservative.

Which declension class a given noun belongs to is the result of the interplay of its morphonetic shape and grammatical gender, though the two factors are correlated to a considerable extent. The nominative singular of a noun (its citation form) usually reveals the gender in the traditional three-way division. Most masculine nouns end in a consonant (the suffix being $\emptyset$), as in (1c), most feminines end in *-a*, as in (1a), and most neuters end in *-o* or *-e*, as in (1a). This correlation is

not absolute, but it delineates the major declension paradigms.² The three masculine genders are normally distinguished by different patterns of syncretism in the accusative forms (matched by different agreement markers, cf. fn. 1).

The defining parameter for gender is the distinctions of agreement markers on noun modifiers (Hockett 1958: 231 after Corbett 1991: 1, cf. also fn. 1). Thus, a Polish noun has a set value of this category, which manifests itself in the inflection of noun modifiers and verb forms based on the past tense. As previously mentioned, in practice gender is usually deducible from the form of the noun itself. The labels “masculine” and “feminine” imply a semantic basis for the gender system, not really strong in Polish (Kucala 1978: 175), but still perceivable. Gender is mostly a formal grammatical phenomenon apart from the opposition of masculine personal and feminine in nouns for people, which will prove crucial here.

To further complicate the assignment of declension class, the morphonetic shape concerns not only the very final sound of the basic form, but also the last sound of the stem (which is word-final if the suffix is zero). Stem-final consonants may be *hard*, i.e. non-palatalised, or *soft*, i.e. palatal(ised), there are also intermediate categories. Suffixes for some grammatical values depend on this division. Nouns with different types of stems are distributed across all genders. Table 1 exemplifies the major feminine paradigms and the hard-stem masculine personal paradigm for comparison.

Several minor paradigms include nouns falling outside of the scope of the correlation described above. There may be a “mismatch” of the nominative singular suffix and gender, as in masculine nouns ending in *-a*, e.g. *władca* ‘ruler’ and *mężczyzna* ‘man’ or feminine nouns ending in a consonant, e.g. *mysz* ‘mouse’ and *ciemność* ‘darkness’. The nominative singular may end in a way not covered by the general rule, as in feminine nouns in *-i*, e.g. the honorific *pani* ‘madam, lady, Mrs’ and *władczyni* ‘female ruler’. Still other nouns use the distinct suffixes of adjectives, e.g. *szeregowy* ‘private (military rank), vir’, *królowa* ‘queen, f’, *znależne* ‘finder’s fee, n’. In general, minor declension classes have a clearer semantic profile than the major ones, cf. the discussion of (4) and fn. 10. Let us note that many of them are productive patterns due to association with specific derivational suffixes e.g. the agentive *-c(a)* in *władca*, feminine *-yn(i)/-in(i)* in *władczyni* or abstract *-ość* in *ciemność* above.

In sum, the main factors influencing noun declension in Polish are gender and morphonetics. Some (groups of) words show further idiosyncrasies. The re-

²They are “major” in terms of the number of nouns, but also the ease of acquisition. Smoczyńska (1985: 625–626) shows that nouns of minor classes are problematic for young speakers.

Table 1: Several major declension paradigms

	mama 'mum'	ciocia 'aunt'	córka 'daughter'	uczennica 'pupil, F'	doktor 'doctor, M'
	F hard stem	F soft stem	F velar stem	F historically soft stem	VIR hard stem
NOM SG	mam-a	cioci-a	córk-a	uczennic-a	doktor-Ø
GEN SG	mam-y	cioc-i	córk-i	uczennic-y	doktor-a
DAT SG	mami-e	cioc-i	córc-e	uczennic-y	doktor-owi
ACC SG	mam-ę	cioci-ę	córk-ę	uczennic-ę	doktor-a
INS SG	mam-ą	cioci-ą	córk-ą	uczennic-ą	doktor-em
LOC SG	mami-e	cioc-i	córc-e	uczennic-y	doktorz-e
VOC SG	mam-o	cioci-u	córk-o	uczennic-o	doktorz-e
NOM PL	mam-y	cioci-e	córk-i	uczennic-e	doktorz-y
GEN PL	mam-Ø	cioc-Ø	córek-Ø	uczennic-Ø	doktor-ów
DAT PL	mam-om	cioci-om	córk-om	uczennic-om	doktor-om
ACC PL	mam-y	cioci-e	córk-i	uczennic-e	doktor-ów
INS PL	mam-ami	cioci-ami	córk-ami	uczennic-ami	doktor-ami
LOC PL	mam-ach	cioci-ach	córk-ach	uczennic-ach	doktor-ach
VOC PL	mam-y	cioci-e	córk-i	uczennic-e	doktorz-y

sultant number of paradigms (exact sets of suffixes in the 14-slot grid) is considerable. However, there are numerous similarities across the paradigms. For example, the feminine classes in Table 1 share some suffixes in the singular. The suffixes for other cases differ, but all four patterns syncretise the dative and locative. In those represented by *ciocia* and *uczennica*, the genitive is also identical to these two cases. In the plural, the similarities are even more evident and some suffixes are shared with the masculine class (and others). Thus, the numerous exact sets of suffixes for the 14 slots are to a large extent variations on relatively few basic patterns.

2.2 Lack of declension in Polish

Let us now review the factors that make some Polish nouns resist inflection. Most of them are borrowings, but as we shall see, native words (and new coinages) can also be uninflected. The first factor is the incompatibility of morphonetic shape of the given word and available declension paradigms. Consider words ending

in *-u*, which cannot be a nominative suffix, so the whole word is interpreted as the stem. This does not help much because such stems (with putative zero suffixes)³ still cannot be associated with any pattern of declension. Consequently, loanwords like *malibu* in (3), *kakadu* 'cockatoo', *Peru*, *Nehru* or *Katmandu* remain uninflectable.

- (3) butelk-a malibu
bottle-NOM.SG malibu[GEN.SG]
'a bottle of malibu'

Apart from the final *-u*, stressed final vowels are similarly problematic for the Polish system. These are found in loanwords that preserve the original oxytone pattern and in many acronyms (including native ones), e.g. *menu* [mɛ'ni], *Delacroix*, *Calais*, *BBC* or *PKO* (name of a bank).

To make sense of (4), we must factor in semantics. Even though nouns with final consonants are commonplace in Polish and they normally inflect, they are masculine (with the suffix *-Ø*) and the corresponding paradigm is masculine, cf. (5).

- (4) Czy nie przestaje Pan-i być rozsądn-ą
Q NEG stop.3SG Mrs-NOM.SG be.INF rational-INS.SG.F
businesswoman?
businesswoman[INS.SG]
'Don't you stop being a rational businesswoman?'
- (NKJP, Przepiórkowski et al. 2012)
- (5) Czy nie przestaje Pan-Ø być rozsądn-ym
Q NEG stop.3SG Mr-NOM.SG be.INF rational-INS.SG.M
businessmen-em?
businessman-INS.SG
'Don't you stop being a rational businessman?'

Because of its meaning, *bizneswoman* in (4) must be feminine and the gender assignment does not allow the noun to decline according to the masculine paradigm. This is a clear case of incompatibility: a potentially matching paradigm

³Some grammars of Polish posit zero suffixes for all paradigm slots of uninflectable nouns (e.g. Orzechowska 1998: 271). Here, subtler distinctions are necessary. In glosses for normally uninflectable nouns inflectional categories (retrievable from the context) are shown in brackets, cf. (3). In the case of normally inflectable nouns, zero suffixes (in opposition to non-zero suffixes on the same words) are used, cf. (5). In clear cases of contextual uninflectedness no morpheme segmentation is used and the category values given match the form of the noun and not the context, cf. (7a).

exists, but it is not applied because of the given noun's semantics, reflected in gender assignment.

A similar issue arises with words that have a final -y [i], which is a nominative singular suffix in the masculine paradigm for adjectives. Nouns that inflect this way are typically masculine personal, cf. *szeregowy* 'private' in Section 2.1. Foreign male names that match the pattern, e.g. *Harry*, inflect, while semantically unfit borrowings, e.g. *brandy*, do not.

Neuter nouns in -um, e.g. *kuriozum* 'oddity' are a unique group in that they do not inflect in the singular, but do so in the plural. The pattern has arisen with Latin borrowings, but is productive, as many other minor ones. A very recent (and likely short-lived) example is *miraculum*, a name of type of magical object in *Miraculous: Tales of Ladybug & Cat Noir*, an animated television series from the 2010s.

Let us stress that when nouns are borrowed into Polish, the original form is taken to be the nominative singular. Numerous noun forms have a final -u, but it serves as a suffix of oblique cases. Borrowed foreign forms like *malibu* are never interpreted as having such a suffix.⁴ The nominative singular functions as the basic form in the Polish grammatical tradition and is used as the entry form in dictionaries. The behaviour of borrowings shows that this convention is supported by the feeling of native speakers.

The second factor promoting lack of inflection can be called the unfamiliar character of the noun. Even though the place names *Vancouver* and *Hanower* 'Hannover' end in exactly the same sounds in Polish, only the latter regularly inflects. This factor is very elusive and cannot be boiled down to geographical distance or low frequency.⁵ Names of many cities in Germany, a neighbour of Poland, do not inflect, e.g. *Essen* or *Monachium* 'Munich'. On the other hand, names of numerous very distant and clearly exotic places do inflect, e.g. *Osaka* or *Bangkok*.

Similar observations can be made about common nouns for concepts of foreign origin. Many such words are normally uninflectable, even though possibly matching paradigms exist, e.g. *judo*, *karate*, *reggae*, *kakao* 'cocoa', and *mango*. Other established borrowings do inflect, however. The following examples are

⁴Following this line of thought, (3) could be interpreted as having a genitive suffix -u, found in masculine inanimate paradigms, yielding a nominative form **malib*. In reality, borrowings are never treated this way and the very idea would seem absurd to native speakers. This fantasy scenario is inspired by the treatment of loanwords in Kambaata (Cushitic, Ethiopia), which are always inflected no matter what phonetic shape they have (Treis 2023).

⁵In the case of the two city names, this is completely mistaken. *Vancouver* is actually more frequent in the NKJP than *Hanower*, 4,503 vs. 3,331 attestations, respectively.

semantically similar to the previous set: *joga* ‘yoga’, *rap*, *cha-cha*, *kawa* ‘coffee’ and *papaja* ‘papaya’.

To sum up, some foreign words function as quotes from other languages (Krzyżanowski 2013: 36, 40) and do not inflect, although which ones behave so is really a matter of language use, which is not uniform either (see below). According to Dunaj (2004: 84–85), the features promoting uninflectedness are low frequency of the potential paradigm and the given borrowing as such, as well as the learned character of the word.

We mentioned in passing the idea of using words as quotes. In fact, this is a typical environment for contextual suspension of inflection. Thus, in (6) the normally inflectable word *kwiat* does not adopt the form expected after the preposition *do*. The basic form is used for metalinguistic quoting.

- (6) rym-Ø do “kwiat”
 rhyme-NOM.SG PREP flower.NOM.SG
 ‘a rhyme for [the word] flower’ (NKJP)

Note that an inflected word form can be quoted as well, but then its overt categories are not tied to the actual context. However, the unchanged basic form of declinable words in Polish appears often in structures that are not straightforward quoting, namely APPPOSITIONS, cf. (7).

- (7) a. nad rzek-ą San
 upon river-INS.SG San.NOM.SG
 b. nad San-em
 upon San-INS.SG
 ‘on the river San’

The name in (7a) remains in the nominative, quoted, as it were, and the syntactic functions of the whole phrase are marked on the common noun *rzeka* ‘river’. This happens despite the name being otherwise inflectable as in (7b). Appositional phrases where one noun (usually more general and coming first) is inflected while the other is given in the basic form, even though it is generally inflectable, constitute a common pattern in modern Polish, which easily incorporates uninflectable nouns. The phrase *strusi emu* in (8) follows the pattern of apposition observed in (7a). The more general noun is declined and thus shows the grammatical relations of the whole phrase to other words whereas the more specific noun bears no inflectional marking. The difference is that *emu*, like *malibu* in (3), is always uninflectable, unlike the river name in (7).

- (8) przodk-owie dzisiaj-sz-yh strus-i emu
 ancestor-NOM.PL today.ADJ-GEN.PL ostrich-GEN.PL emu[GEN.PL]
 ‘the ancestors of modern emus’ (NKJP)

For many of the nouns mentioned so far there is variation in usage. This is certainly true about the very fluid concept of unfamiliar character. If a given noun is normally not declined, but its morphonetic shape does not preclude assigning a declension paradigm, it is likely that some speakers will inflect it. For example, *Vancouver* may be uninflectable in standard usage, but some speakers do decline the name.⁶

A historical parallel is the usage of the noun *radio*. Initially, the word was uninflectable, presumably due to novelty of the invention, coupled with unfamiliar phonetics, the palatalised plosive [dʲ] being rare in Polish. Today, however, the inflected forms have become dominant. Thus, some tendency to eliminate particular cases of uninflectedness can be noted. This process leads to variation in contemporary usage and changes of the properties of lexemes over longer stretches of time.

Changes such as that of the noun *radio* are rather expected; if nouns generally decline, it is natural that new “unfamiliar” nouns eventually comply with the regular pattern. However, Kurek (2019) documents an opposite tendency to avoid declension in present day Polish. One context in which normally inflectable nouns are used in their basic forms is official documents. This is linked to generating them on the basis of electronic databases. Various data, particularly surnames, are stored in nominative forms and then inserted directly into documents, whatever the actual linguistic context (Kurek 2019: 57). This kind of “officialese” may serve as a model for some speakers in other situations. Uncertainty about the actual forms of particular words also plays a role (Kurek 2019: 61–62). Faced with the risk of creating a wrong inflected form, speakers tend to prefer uninflectedness as the safest option, even though this may sometimes obscure the meaning or lead to misunderstandings (Kurek 2019: 157–159). Such usage has not been accepted as standard as yet, but is clearly present. The process is most advanced with surnames. These normally appear in apposition with given names, which resist the tendency much more and usually inflect.

⁶There are 2 attestations of *do Vancouveru* ‘to Vancouver’ in the NKJP and 132 of the standard phrase without inflection. There are 30 attestations of *w Vancouverze* ‘in Vancouver’ and 1210 of the version without inflection.

3 The uninflected words for women in present-day Polish

3.1 The array of constructions

The uninflected nouns referring to women represent a regular pattern, but are clearly a minority among feminine personal nouns in Polish. The examples below present both the uninflected forms and competing patterns. We shall start by defining the relevant word types. The focal group will be called U-FORMS (for ‘uninflected’), nouns referring to women that have no inflectional marking in syntactic positions where non-zero suffixes are expected. The major competing pattern are D-FORMS (for ‘derivation’), nouns referring to women that have clear morphologically related masculine counterparts (and so can be construed as derived from them), but inflect normally according to feminine paradigms. There are still M-FORMS (for ‘masculine’), masculine personal nouns with inflection according to masculine paradigms, but used with reference to women.⁷ We should stress that there is actual competition among these word types, i.e. one lexical concept may be expressed by more than one type. (9–10) exemplify U-forms.

- (9) Z psycholog nie chciała gadać.
 with psychologist[INS.SG] NEG want.PST.F talk.INF
 ‘With the psychologist she wouldn’t talk.’ (NKJP)⁸
- (10) Zainteresowałem pomysł-em pani-ą notariusz
 interest.PST.M.1SG idea-INS.SG Mrs-ACC.SG notary[ACC.SG]
 Agnieszka-ę Sienkiewicz.
 Agnieszka-ACC.SG Sienkiewicz[ACC.SG]
 ‘I got the notary, Agnieszka Sienkiewicz, interested in the idea.’ (NKJP)

The common nouns *psycholog* in (9) and *notariusz* in (10) as well as the surname in (10) have no marking even though their syntactic positions require oblique cases that normally have non-zero suffixes. The three nouns are identical in form to the nominative singular of their masculine counterparts. With masculine referents they would inflect: *z psychologi-em*, *notariusz-a*, *Sienkiewicz-a*, cf.

⁷A non-negligible number of words referring to women (which we could label F-FORMS) fall beyond the scope of the division presented here. These are inflectable feminine nouns that are morphologically independent from their masculine counterparts, e.g. *siostra* ‘sister’ vs. *brat* ‘brother’.

⁸Examples like (9) should theoretically be retrievable from corpora because of the characteristic mismatch between the preposition (taking an oblique case) and the following U-form which looks like a nominative. Yet, such queries mostly yield noise, phrases with various forms wrongly tagged as nominatives.

the difference between (4) and (5). Applying the originally masculine nouns for feminine referents whilst keeping the unchanged basic form across the whole paradigm is the formation of *derived U-forms*, a productive pattern of word-formation. The common nouns involved are usually ultimately borrowings, as in (9–10), but many are old ones and not necessarily perceived as foreign. Among surnames a great number of U-forms are native. Apart from derived U-forms, there are also uninflectable loanwords referring to women, e.g. *bizneswoman* in (4). These are not identical to their masculine counterparts (or may not have them at all) and will be referred to as *independent U-forms*.

To explain the uninflectedness here, we need only generalise the analysis of (4). Words like *psycholog*, *notariusz*, etc. pose a problem for the Polish system if they are to refer to women. The word-final consonants in the basic form are characteristic of masculine paradigms, but the words are supposed to be grammatically feminine to match actual reference. As a result, the feminine declension cannot be applied because of the morphonetic structure of the words, and the masculine personal one is not used either because of semantics.⁹

Uninflectedness is only one possible resolution of the conflict of morphonetic shape and gender. Apart from inflection, Polish also has rich derivational morphology. If the morphonetic shape of a word is problematic for the given use, a derivational mechanism can rectify it. This is how D-forms come into existence, examples of which are (11–13).

- (11) Apetyczn-a trzydziestolat-k-a o wyglądzi-e
 attractive-NOM.SG.F thirty.year-NMLZ-NOM.SG PREP appearance-LOC.SG
 prowincjonaln-ej nauczyciel-k-i.
 provincial-GEN.SG.F teacher-F-GEN.SG
 ‘An attractive 30-year-old looking like a provincial teacher.’ (NKJP)

The word *nauczycielki* in (11) is clearly distinct from the U-forms above and can be regarded as a regular element of the Polish system; the inflection is present and it is in line with semantics. Note the feminine suffix *-k(a)*, also present in (2c), which turns the masculine noun *nauczyciel* ‘teacher’ into the feminine *nauczycielka*, which undergoes regular inflection.

⁹Section 2.1 mentions a paradigm for feminines ending in consonants. It might then seem that there is no conflict after all. Alas, this declension class only has nouns with (historically) soft word-final consonants, which is not the case for the majority of the words that appear as U-forms. It also contains mostly inanimate nouns and few for animals, e.g. *mysz* ‘mouse’. Any personal nouns following the pattern are long obsolete, e.g. *jątrew* ‘husband’s brother’s wife’.

Most D-forms are created by suffixation, but some are conversions (zero derivations).¹⁰ A conspicuous (and controversial, cf. Section 4.4) example is *ministra* in (12), with exactly the same stem as the masculine *minister*. The word is formed by direct application of a major feminine paradigm (including *-a* for the nominative singular). Thus, even though the basic form *minister-Ø* has no matching feminine paradigm (as was the case with all the U-forms above), the stem *minist(e)r-* can be matched with no problem. This comes at the price of having a distinct basic form of the word, clearly a change noticeable for the speakers.

- (12) Now-a ministr-a kultur-y Szwecj-i ma
 new-NOM.SG.F minister-NOM.SG culture-GEN.SG Sweden-GEN.SG have.3SG
 dred-y.
 dreadlock-ACC.PL

‘The new Swedish minister for culture has dreadlocks.’¹¹

The noun *radna* ‘councillor, F’ in (13) shares the stem with the masculine *radny*, but these are nouns of the adjectival paradigm. Adjectives have gender as an inflectional category. Hence, whenever a reference to a woman needs to be made with concepts expressed by such nouns, the proper inflectional suffixes are directly available in the paradigm.

- (13) Odpowiedź-Ø nie usatysfakcjonowała radn-ej
 answer-NOM.SG NEG satisfy.PST.F councillor-GEN.SG.F
 Binder.
 Binder[GEN.SG]

‘The answer did not satisfy councillor Binder.’ (NKJP)

Also the word *trzydziestolatka* ‘30-year-old, F’ in (11) has the same stem as the masculine *trzydziestolatek*. The two are parallel derivations from the phrase meaning ‘thirty years’ rather than a direct instance of conversion. Still, the morphological closeness of both words is absolutely clear.

M-forms are exemplified by the words *nauczycielem* in (14), *ministra* in (15) and *autora* in (1c). Even though the reference is clearly feminine, these are inflected forms with suffixes of masculine paradigms. The adjective in (14) has a masculine suffix, which shows that M-forms are grammatically masculine nouns, just with female referents.

¹⁰Derived U-forms are also conversions – from a major masculine personal paradigm to the “fully syncretic” class of uninflectable nouns.

¹¹<https://wyborcza.pl/7,75410,24399632,nowa-ministra-kultury-szwecji-ma-dredy-i-palilatravke.html> Accessed 24.06.2024.

- (14) Pan-i Grażyn-a nie jest surow-ym nauczyciel-em.
Mrs-NOM.SG Grażyna-NOM.SG NEG be.3SG strict-INS.SG.M teacher-INS.SG
‘[Mrs] Grażyna [given name] is not a strict teacher.’ (NKJP)
- (15) rocznic-a śmierc-i Izabel-i Jarug-i
anniversary-NOM.SG death-GEN.SG Izabela-GEN.SG Jaruga-GEN.SG
Nowack-iej, ministr-a polityk-i społeczn-ej
Nowacka-GEN.SG.F minister-GEN.SG policy-GEN.SG social-GEN.SG.F
‘the anniversary of the death of Izabela Jaruga-Nowacka, the Minister for
Social Policy’¹²

Let us add that (14) involves a noun used predicatively in a copular construction and this is one context in which M-forms appear regularly and U-forms are very rare. D-forms, by contrast, are fine; an alternative way to express the meaning of (14) would be with the phrase *surow-q nauczyciel-k-q*.

Table 2 summarises the properties of the three relevant word types. The distribution of the structures is partially determined by constructional, lexical and stylistic factors, discussed at length in Section 3.3. The restriction on U-forms being used predicatively has just been mentioned. As for the lexical factors, different concepts applied to women favour different structures, to the extent that only one of the three theoretically possible formations may be used. The role of register (and possibly ideology) can be noted with the words meaning ‘minister’ above. (12) uses a D-form, (15) an M-form, a U-form is also possible. (12) is part of a headline in a progressive daily *Gazeta Wyborcza*, which at some point decided to adopt the innovative D-form for female holders of ministerial offices, cf. Section 4.4. (15) comes from a government website and the M-form has a dry bureaucratic feel to it. In fact, the U-form *minister*, as in (24), is the most common way to refer to female ministers.

Thus, there is some form of “division of labour” between the word types, but at the same time there is also competition between them. Even though we can clearly distinguish three types of noun usage, the speakers seem to perceive a binary opposition: D-forms (showing feminine reference directly) vs. the other two. The same transpires from linguistic analyses: even if the problem of unflectedness is acknowledged and discussed, it is subordinate to the main division: D-forms are typically labelled *feminine forms* while U-forms and M-forms are *masculine*.¹³

¹²<https://www.gov.pl/web/rodzina/8-rocznica-smierci-izabeli-jarugi-nowackiej>
Accessed 24.06.2024.

¹³A notable exception is Krzyżanowski (2013: 21, 172ff.).

Table 2: Summary of the properties of the discussed word types

	U-forms	D-forms	M-forms	masculine nouns
reference	feminine	feminine	feminine	masculine
basic form (NOM SG)	same as M noun (and M-form)	distinctly F	same as M noun (and U-form)	distinctly M (and same as U-form and M-form)
inflectional paradigm(s)	no marking	feminine	masculine	masculine
morphological relation to M counterpart	identical to M NOM SG (conversion) or no direct relation	suffixation or (pseudo) conversion	full identity	n/a
examples in this section	<i>psycholog</i> in (9), <i>notariusz</i> in (10), <i>Sienkiewicz</i> in (10)	<i>panią</i> in (10), <i>trzydziesto- latka</i> in (11), <i>nauczycielki</i> in (11), <i>ministra</i> in (12), <i>radna</i> in (13), <i>Nowackiej</i> in (15)	<i>nauczycielem</i> in (14), <i>ministra</i> in (15)	n/a

Let us also consider the status of the three word types as lexical units. It is obvious that D-forms are separate lexemes from masculine nouns. Likewise, it is clear that M-forms are only special ways of using masculine nouns. Independent U-forms, like *bizneswoman*, must also be lexemes of their own. The question is more complex for derived U-forms. It is often assumed that they are twin lexemes of their masculine counterparts, i.e. that there is an inflectable masculine lexeme *minister*₁ and a separate uninflectable feminine one *minister*₂. The idea was apparently first suggested by Kucala (1978: 68) and is included in academic grammars (e.g. Grzegorzczkova & Puzynina 1998a: 368; Grzegorzczkova & Puzynina 1998b: 422). Some more recent works refer to this position as a given (Jadacka

2006: 126; RJP 2012; Andrejewicz 2019: 626), but it is not universally accepted. Łaziński (2006: 227) argues strongly against it while Bobrowski (2012: 229) considers it only as a possible option. The issue will resurface in Sections 3.3.2 and 4.5.

Table 3: Major inflectional types of Polish surnames

surname type	masculine form (further exs. in brackets)	feminine form	traditional feminine forms (as of early 20 th cent. in standard language)
suffix <i>-sk(i)</i> and variants	Kowalski (Nowacki)	Kowalska	Kowalska
final <i>-a</i>	Duda (Jaruga)	Duda	Dudzina/Dudowa (married) Dudzianka/Dudówna (unmarried)
final consonant	Nowak (Sienkiewicz)	Nowak (U-form)	Nowakowa (married) Nowakówna (unmarried)

Women's surnames present a similar level of variation to common nouns. As shown in Table 3, surnames with the adjectival suffix *-sk(i)* have regular D-forms, while surnames with final consonants regularly have U-forms. The most interesting group, not fitting any of the word types above, are those with the final *-a*, which have identical inflectable forms for men and women, with exactly the same inflection in the singular, following the feminine paradigm. The grammatical gender of the surname is decided by semantics across all the types. Traditionally, all types had distinct D-forms, revealing not only gender, but also a given woman's marital status.¹⁴

¹⁴There used to be greater variation of D-forms than shown in Table 3. Women could also be referred to by D-forms based on their husbands or fathers' given names or positions. In the early modern times, similar derivative labels existed for young men, many of which developed into patronymic surnames.

3.2 U-forms in use

Let us explore the current usage of U-forms in detail. (16–17) are quite typical examples.

- (16) Głos-Ø Wybrzeż-a ma now-ą redaktor
voice-NOM.SG coast-GEN.SG have.3SG new-ACC.SG.F editor[ACC.SG]
naczeln-ą.
main-ACC.SG.F
‘[The newspaper] Głos Wybrzeża has a new editor-in-chief.’ (NKJP)
- (17) Lekarz powiedziała, że może bez problem-u
doctor[NOM.SG] say.PST.F that may.3SG without problem-GEN.SG
jeść.
eat.INF
‘The doctor said that [the baby] may eat [this kind of food] without a
problem.’ (NKJP)

The suffixes on noun modifiers as in (16) and on past verb forms in (17) are standard signals of the feminine gender and the U-forms in the examples are clearly feminine. However, such elements are not always present, cf. (9), where there is no overt marking of gender, but the feminine reference is clear too. This proves that among personal nouns the lack of inflection functions as a signal of feminine gender in its own right, as noted by Obrębska-Jabłońska (1949).¹⁵

If a U-form appears in the subject position, it is identical to the corresponding masculine noun with a zero suffix. A past tense verb may show gender as in (17), but not all sentences are past. Those like (18) leave the gender of the referent underdetermined. This follows directly from the rules that establish the class of U-forms, but is untypical of Polish, esp. with specific referents (Łaziński 2006: 263), cf. fn. 17 and the discussion of (28) and (32).

- (18) Jakby nie rozumiał, co doktor mówi.
as_if NEG understand.PST.M what.ACC doctor[NOM.SG] say.3SG
‘As if he didn’t understand what the doctor was saying.’ (NKJP)¹⁶

¹⁵Curiously enough, even though she recognises uninflectedness as a gender signal, Obrębska-Jabłońska herself describes the use of U-forms as “masculinisation” (1949: 1), in line with the general tendency to block U-forms and M-forms together against D-forms, cf. Section 3.1.

¹⁶It is impossible to retrieve easily examples of U-forms like (18) from corpora. U-forms are tagged the same as masculine nouns and true examples of the latter dominate the results absolutely.

Misunderstanding sentences like (18) is probably relatively seldom a risk in real-life communication as the gender will have been established earlier in the discourse.¹⁷ Without any such cues the default interpretation would likely be that the sentence is about a male doctor.¹⁸ Thus, plain U-forms, even though attested and used, may feel somewhat inadequate.

In fact, U-forms are very often combined in apposition with other feminine nouns, typically inflectable ones. In (19–20) U-forms are preceded by more general inflectable nouns, which directly show the syntactic relation of the phrases to the surrounding context. The uninflectedness becomes much less problematic in apposition, the U-form functions like a label quoted in an unchanged basic form, as in (6), (7a) and (8).

- (19) T-a spraw-a jest ważn-a dla pan-i
this-NOM.SG.F matter-NOM.SG be.3SG important-NOM.SG.F for Mrs-GEN.SG
prezes.
president[GEN.SG]
'This matter is important for [you,] madame president [of the company].'
(NKJP)
- (20) Węgr-y też mają kobiet-ę minister
Hungary-NOM.PL also have.3PL woman-ACC.SG minister[ACC.SG]
spraw-Ø zagraniczn-ych.
affair-GEN.PL foreign-GEN.PL
'Hungary also has a female foreign minister.'
(NKJP)

The use of the honorific *pani* in apposition with U-forms, as in (19) or (10) above, is a regular pattern in the language. Other words can be used similarly, but this rare usage always meets specific needs of a given context, e.g. in (20) the noun *kobietę* explicitly labels the gender of the referent. The honorific combines regularly not only with common nouns, but also with surnames of women, both inflectable and uninflected. Table 4 shows the importance of the appositional pattern in terms of frequency. With the phrase *dla pani prezes* from (19) as a starting point, the NKJP was queried for the preposition *dla* and the noun form *prezes* with one intervening word possible. The results show a strong dominance of the apposition with the honorific for the U-form. No such effect is visible in the data for corresponding masculine phrases. This suggests that *pani* has developed

¹⁷In the context of (18), we learn two sentences earlier that the doctor is a woman from her D-form surname.

¹⁸We can then see a point in regarding U-forms as “masculine”.

into a kind of auxiliary noun with U-forms, a carrier of overt inflectional marking and analytic marker of the feminine gender, cf. the discussion of (32). Note also that in the query results there is no single example parallel to (20), i.e. with a common noun other than *pani* used in apposition with the noun *prezes*.

Table 4: Frequencies of various types of phrase structure in phrases *dla* (...) *prezes(a)* ‘for the president (of a company)’ in the NKJP.

phrase structure	no. of relevant examples	%
<i>dla pani prezes</i> (honorific + U-form)	43	80%
<i>dla</i> ADJ.F/DET.F <i>prezes</i> (F modifier + U-form)	4	7%
<i>dla prezes</i> (no intervening words)	7	13%
total F	54	
<i>dla pana prezesa</i> (honorific + M noun)	74	6%
<i>dla</i> ADJ.M/DET.M <i>prezesa</i> (modifier+ M noun)	137	11%
<i>dla prezesa</i> (no intervening words)	1,034	83%
total M	1,245	

As for women’s surnames, they commonly appear in apposition, with the noun *pani* and with given names, most of which inflect.¹⁹ In (10), such typical structures are joined into a single complex apposition: honorific – profession – given name – surname. Two nouns are inflected, two are U-forms.

Another natural combination is that of a given woman’s function and her surname, as in (13). In fact, of the 7 examples with no intervening word before the U-form in Table 4, as many as 4 involve a surname in apposition, coming after the word *prezes*. In such phrases both nouns may well be U-forms, as in (21).

- (21) polityczn-a burz-a po twitterow-ym wpisi-e
 political-NOM.SG.F storm-NOM.SG after twitter.ADJ-LOC.SG.M post-LOC.SG
 kurator Nowak
 superintendent[GEN.SG] Nowak[GEN.SG]
 ‘a political storm after a tweet by the school superintendent Nowak’²⁰

¹⁹The vast majority of female given names in Polish end in *-a* in the basic form and inflect according to the major feminine paradigms. The few rather rare exceptions are U-forms.

²⁰<https://wiadomosci.dziennik.pl/polityka/artykuly/8578116,barbara-nowak-lex-czarnek-barbara-nowacka.html> Accessed 26.06.2024.

As in (9), there are no direct signals of feminine gender in (21), but the feminine reference is perfectly clear because of the lack of expected inflection. A parallel phrase about a male superintendent by the same name would obviously need to inflect: *kurator-a Nowak-a*, cf. the discussion of (4–5) and (9–10).

The opposition between the inflectable male version of a surname and the uninflected female one extends to many foreign surnames. For example, the surname *Clinton* inflects when Bill Clinton is referred to, but does not when Hillary Clinton is, but cf. Section 4.2. Here the given names behave identically to the surname: *Bill* is regularly inflected as a masculine noun, while *Hillary*, not fitting any feminine paradigm, is a U-form.

(22), the title of a paper devoted to U-forms, exemplifies how surnames function as plain U-forms. As we can see, this is parallel to what we observed with common nouns.

- (22) Baran mówi o Kowal.
Baran[NOM.SG] talk.3SG about Kowal[LOC.SG]
‘Baran talks about [Ms.] Kowal.’ (Pawłowski 1951)

The surname *Kowal* in (22) is in a non-subject position and the lack of overt inflection identifies it as a U-form and a woman’s name, as in (9) and (21). However, for the surname *Baran*, which appears as the subject, it cannot be decided from the sentence alone if the person in question is a man or a woman, as in (18).

To sum up, U-forms are an established and productive pattern. Among them there are common nouns for professions, professional functions and titles as well as surnames (including numerous native ones). These words do not have any overt marking of the feminine gender, but trigger feminine agreement. However, the lack of inflection on nouns is a conspicuous absence in Polish²¹ and so it has developed into a signal of the feminine gender by itself. This signalling fails, however, if the given noun is in the nominative singular, which for derived U-forms is identical to the masculine counterpart. There is no grammatical difference between common nouns and personal names. All the effects related to uninflectedness can be observed in both groups.

The feminine agreement triggered by U-forms is the reason Kucała (1978: 61, 68) concluded they are feminine nouns, thus excluding any mismatch of gender between the modifiers or past verb forms and the nouns of an apparently masculine shape.

²¹Krzyżanowski (2013: 35) vividly describes uninflected nouns, including U-forms, as “refraining from inflection”.

Despite their established status in the system, U-forms are still a very odd class in Polish. This fuels the use of a rival pattern, D-forms. Taking into account the most general features of the language, one might expect a very strong systemic pressure for establishing D-forms across the whole personal noun lexicon. As can be inferred so far, this has not been the case, but see the discussion of recent developments in Section 4.4.

Another effect related to the “odd” character of U-forms is the ease with which they enter into appositional structures. In this way, they can “hide” behind inflectable nouns, which show syntactic relations through case marking and manifest gender explicitly. The main inflectable nouns entering into these structures are the honorific *pani* and given names. Apposition is thus a major strategy of integrating U-forms in the grammatical system heavily reliant on inflection.

3.3 Constraints on the use of U-forms

3.3.1 Overview

The use of U-forms is limited in several ways in present-day Polish. Some restrictions are grammatical. One is the virtual absence of U-forms from the copular construction where M-forms are used rather than U-forms, cf. the discussion of (14), which need not be expanded. U-forms are also less free in the plural, see the next section. Apart from that there are lexical and stylistic factors. Groups of lexemes show preferences for particular word types – this is the “division of labour” between U-forms, D-forms and M-forms. However, there is also substantial (and increasing) overlap and competition between the types. When forms of two or even three types co-exist for the same lexical concept, the difference between them is related to factors like register or ideology.

3.3.2 Plural number

The examples so far have all shown U-forms in the singular. Number is the most problematic category for U-forms. As has been shown in Section 3.2, case can usually be inferred from the context as its value must match the requirements of the word governing a given U-form syntactically, even though structurally ambiguous phrases appear in actual use cf. Szpyra-Kozłowska (2021: 340–341). Gender is understood to be feminine due to the lack of inflection. A U-form by itself has no way of differentiation left for number, which is by default understood to be singular.²² A natural solution is to mark plurality around the noun: on

²² An alternative would be for the number to be underspecified in such contexts. This is not the case, however, e.g. (9) refers to one female psychologist, a plural reading is highly unlikely if not downright impossible.

nouns in apposition, modifiers or verbs. In (23) the U-form surname is combined with the plural of the honorific *pani*. Yet again apposition makes the functioning of an uninflected noun in Polish syntax possible.

- (23) Postanowiono pomóc pani-om Anflik w
 decide.PST.IMPERS help.INF Mrs-DAT.PL Anflik[DAT.PL] in
 inn-y sposób-Ø.
 other-ACC.SG.M.INAN way-ACC.SG
 ‘It was decided that the Anflik Ladies will be helped in a different way.’
 (NKJP)

The plural honorific is used regularly, but other potential carriers of plurality are not unproblematic. Łaziński (2006: 227) argues that derived U-forms simply cannot be used as plural nouns in their own right, giving an example with the “evidently faulty” phrase **między dwiema minister* ‘between two [female] ministers’. A phrase with an apposition, parallel to (23), *między paniami minister* would be acceptable, however. An independent U-form in plural is also fine: *między dwiema lady* ‘between two ladies’.

Łaziński’s conclusion is that derived U-forms are not separate uninflectable lexemes, but simply special cases of usage of masculine nouns (otherwise normally inflectable) for female referents. The lack of marking would then prove to be simply contextual uninflectedness – in contrast to the view taken by Kucała (1978), cf. Section 3.1. It follows that there are two separate ways in which masculine personal lexemes can be used to refer to women, U-forms and M-forms. The analysis runs into problems when we consider that U-forms trigger feminine agreement. Łaziński (2006: 231) explains the resultant gender mismatch (non-existent in Kucała’s approach, cf. Section 3.2) as “agreement *ad sensum*”, i.e. a grammatically masculine noun combines with feminine modifiers or past verb forms on the basis of actual feminine reference. This special kind of agreement would then be obligatory for U-forms, but never happens with M-forms, cf. (14). The firmness of Łaziński’s conclusions is shaken by the fact that sentences with the supposedly unacceptable structures are in fact attested, e.g. (24).

- (24) Słow-a t-e kierowały obi-e
 word-ACC.PL this-ACC.PL.NVIR direct.PST.PL.NVIR both-NOM.PL.F
 minister wyłącznie do osób-Ø, któr-ych (...)
 minister[NOM.PL] only to person-GEN.PL who-GEN.PL
 ‘These words were spoken by both [female] ministers only to people
 who (...)’
 (NKJP)

In (24) plurality is marked on the modifier and the verb form. Ironically, the example includes the very same noun as Łaziński's "faulty" phrase. Yet, sentences like (24) are rather infrequent. To be fair, Łaziński gives a counterexample himself, quoting what he had heard said by a receptionist at the doctor's, given as (25).

- (25) Doktor już przyszły.
 doctor[NOM.PL] already come.PST.PL.NVIR
 'The doctors [all female] have come.' (Łaziński 2006: 227)

Plurality in (25) is shown on the verb only. Łaziński comments that this kind of usage "does not seem to be very common". This observation seems accurate, but such structures still do occur in real language. (26) is a parallel example with an independent U-form. Such sentences are easier to find than ones like (25) even though independent U-forms are generally less common than derived U-forms.

- (26) Dawniej miss były
 early.COMP.ADV beauty_queen[NOM.PL] be.PST.PL.NVIR
 zdan-e tylko na siebie.
 rely.PTCP-NOM.PL.NVIR only on oneself.ACC
 'In the earlier times, beauty queens were left on their own.'²³

In the light of (24–26) it is impossible to accept Łaziński's categorical statements at face value, but the observations are not irrelevant; the counterexamples are infrequent. Table 5 sums up the use of U-forms in plural. The possible carriers of plurality form a hierarchy. Let us add that we are not aware of attestations of U-forms with clearly plural meaning and no formal marking of plurality. If such usage exists at all, it is rare, quite certainly substandard and strongly context-dependent. In contrast to U-forms, the other patterns: D-forms and M-forms as well as masculine personal nouns are used in the plural without restrictions.

In Table 5 we present the general picture of the usage of U-forms in the plural. Since it is extremely difficult to substantiate the frequency labels for the whole class, we resort to corpus data for specific example words, shown in Table 6. We selected three typical U-forms: *minister*, *doktor* 'medical doctor, Ph.D.' and *profesor* 'professor'. The data have been queried separately for different loci of plural marking. These were: the non-nominative plural forms of the honorific, non-nominative feminine forms of basic plural modifying words: *dwie* 'two', *obie*

²³<https://dziennikzachodni.pl/ewa-wojciechowska-dawniej-miss-byly-zdane-tylko-na-siebie-to-był-bład/ar/486300> Accessed 26.06.2024.

Table 5: Occurrence of U-forms in plural contexts

locus of plural marking	occurrence	examples
<i>pani</i> in apposition	regular	(23)
noun modifiers	attested but not common	(24)
finite verb	rare, mostly with independent U-forms	(25–26)

‘both’, *wszystkie* ‘all’ and lastly top-frequency plural verb forms: *są* ‘they are’, *będą* ‘they will (be)’ and *mają* ‘they have’. The first two are placed before the target U-forms in the query, the verb forms after them. The use of non-nominative forms in the first two excludes plural agreement on the verb. For comparison, Table 6 also includes figures for parallel plural phrases with a single D-form *nauczycielka* ‘teacher, F’.

Table 6: Frequencies of various types of plural phrase structure for selected U-forms and D-forms in the NKJP

phrase structure	no. of query results	exs. with single locus of plurality	%
<i>pani</i> (PL, NNOM) + <i>minister/doktor/profesor</i>	23	19	95%
<i>dwie/obie/ wszystkie</i> (PL, NNOM) + <i>minister/doktor/profesor</i>	1	1	5%
<i>minister/doktor/profesor</i> + <i>są/będą/mają</i>	3	0	0%
total U-forms		20	
<i>pani</i> (PL, NNOM) + <i>nauczycielki</i> (PL, NNOM)	83	81	47%
<i>dwie/obie/ wszystkie</i> (PL, NNOM) + <i>nauczycielki</i> (PL, NNOM)	41	41	24%
<i>nauczycielki</i> + <i>są/będą/mają</i>	56	49	29%
total D-forms		171	

Since we are interested in comparing different loci of plural marking, examples with doubled signals of plurality (e.g. both on the modifier and the honorific)

had to be removed from the final count. In the case of U-forms combining with the selected plural verb forms this meant excluding all examples. We have only a single example, cited as (24), of a plural modifier with a U-form even though three different words and three possible modifiers were used in the query. Table 6 shows both the initial figures and the examples with single locus of plurality after the recount. The data confirm the hierarchy of carriers of plural marking suggested in Table 5. The honorific is significantly more common relative to the other types in U-forms than in D-forms. The plural honorific dominates in the results with the U-forms. The distribution of the structures with the D-form is much more even.

3.3.3 Lexical range

Various areas of the personal noun lexicon of Polish show preferences for particular word types when feminine reference is made. In a way, each of the three types is restricted in its lexical range; default or at least common for some words, but rare or even non-existent for some others. We will briefly outline what kind of nouns prefer each of the morphological types, starting with words dispreffering U-forms.

Very many concepts are regularly expressed by D-forms when referring to women. (27) shows pairs of corresponding words for men and women, the feminine ones show relevant morphological division.

- (27) a. Włoch ~ Włosz-k-a
 ‘Italian person’
 b. kuzyn ~ kuzyn-k-a
 ‘cousin’
 c. sąsiad ~ sąsiad-k-a
 ‘neighbour’
 d. artysta ~ artyst-k-a
 ‘artist’
 e. poseł ~ poseł-ank-a
 ‘MP’
 f. sprzedawca ~ sprzedawcz-yn-i
 ‘shop assistant’
 g. szef ~ szef-ow-a
 ‘boss’

- h. hrabia ~ hrab-in-a
‘count(ess)’
- i. diabeł ~ diabl-ic-a
‘devil, evil person’
- j. staruch ~ staruch-a
‘old person (derog.)’

Word pairs such as those in (27) are most consistent with general rules of Polish and constitute the “basic” (Kučała 1978: 49) section among personal nouns. Feminine reference is made with D-forms and U-forms are rare or non-existent. Most of these concepts allow M-forms in copular constructions and masculine nouns in generic use (covering both men and women).²⁴

As for semantics, there are names for nationalities in this group, cf. (27a), as well as family relations, cf. (27b). Apart from that, it is difficult to generalise, but we must note that some words for occupations and functions also appear here, cf. (27d–27f), as well as those for noble titles, cf. (27h).

The standard assumption in Polish linguistics is that D-forms are derived from their masculine counterparts (e.g. Grzegorzczkowska & Puzyńska 1998b: 422; Kučala 1978: 49). While this is right in many cases, Szpyra-Kozłowska (2021: 134–135) points out that it need not be a given. For example, nationality labels for both men and women, as in (27a), are most logically derived from country names, cf. also the discussion of *trzydziestolatka* in (11).

(27) shows the rich array of feminative suffixes in Polish: the most common *-k(a)* in (27a–27d), as well as (2c) and (11) above, *-ank(a)* in (27e), *-yn(i)/-in(i)* in (27f), *-ow(a)* in (27g), *-in(a)* in (27h), *-ic(a)* in (27i). Finally, some D-forms are conversions, cf. (27j) and (12).

The suffix *-k(a)* is the most common and can be considered default. Its disadvantage in the eyes of the speakers is that it is identical to the diminutive one, and the one forming names of objects from personal nouns, e.g. *marynar-k-a* ‘suit jacket, F’ from *marynarz* ‘(navy) sailor, M’, as well as the nominalising one, as in *trzydziestolatka* in (11).²⁵ The variety of suffixes itself may also be problematic when new D-forms are created as the speakers might not be sure which suffix to apply (cf. Szpyra-Kozłowska 2019, see also Sections 4.3 and 4.4).

²⁴(2a–2b) are examples of masculine nouns used generically. An alternative to generic masculines is splitting, as in (2c).

²⁵The identity of the feminative *-k(a)* and suffixes with other meanings may lead to emergence of excessive homophones, which is a factor that supposedly blocks the creation of D-forms in some cases. Szpyra-Kozłowska (2021: 191–192, 262–265), however, points out that homophony of suffixes is common in Polish derivation.

As for inflection, most D-forms follow major feminine paradigms, those in *-yn(i)/-in(i)* belong to a minor class, while the suffix *-ow(a)* builds words of the adjectival declension. Note that even if the masculine noun has the typically feminine *-a* in the basic form, D-forms are usually distinct, cf. (27d), (27f) and (27h).

At the other pole, there are lexemes that can refer to both men and women, but have forms inflected according to masculine paradigms, i.e. they are regularly M-forms when the reference is feminine. D-forms and especially U-forms are rare for such words, but not completely non-existent, cf. (30) and Section 4.1. Examples include *szpieg* 'spy', *wróg* 'enemy', *przechodzień* 'passer-by', *tchórz* 'coward' or *gość* 'guest' as in (28).

- (28) Musi przywitać nasz-ego gości-a osobiście.
 must.3SG welcome.INF our-ACC.SG.M guest-ACC.SG personally
 'He must welcome our guest in person.' (NKJP)

The noun *gościa* in (28) takes a suffix from a masculine paradigm and the masculine gender is evident on the modifier. Without context the sentence may well refer to a male guest. In fact, this would be the default interpretation. A female name appears several paragraphs earlier in the text (28) is taken from, thus making the actual reference clearly feminine.

Łaziński (2006: 267) claims that the nouns of this group are rarely used for specific reference, which is normally associated with clear marking of the referent's gender in Polish. The mismatch between feminine reference and ostensibly masculine form of the nouns is mitigated by the backgrounding of gender in their meaning and non-specific reference. For example, *tchórz* focuses on the feature of character, while *przechodzień* emphasises a momentary role in traffic. This line of reasoning fits some of the words less well, e.g. *gość*, which may often have specific reference, as it does in (28). Similarly, the noun *szpieg* could logically refer to specific individuals as well, the synonymous *agent* is apparently more likely in such contexts (Łaziński 2006: 268). The latter has a regular D-form *agentka* for women as referents.

Apart from the fully explicit marking of femininity by D-forms and its occlusion with M-forms, there is a group of concepts for which U-forms are used regularly. For some of these words, this is the dominant pattern. D-forms may exist as alternatives, but their prevalence and acceptability varies greatly depending on the word. The words appearing as derived U-forms so far in the text are mostly labels for professions and professional titles: *notariusz* 'notary', *psycholog* 'psychologist', *redaktor* 'editor', *lekarz* 'medical doctor', *doktor* 'doctor', *prezes* 'president (e.g. of a company)', *kurator* 'educational superintendent', *profesor* 'professor',

minister ‘minister’. What is common for these words is some level of prestige.²⁶ Indeed, the more prestigious a concept is, the more likely it is to be expressed by a U-form. The model for such usage across various contexts is direct address, which takes the form of the apposition comprising the honorific *pani* and the given U-form, cf. (19). Łaziński (2006: 275–276) claims the use of a word as a regular title of address blocks the possibility of creating a D-form. The blockage is not complete, and has been loosening recently, cf. Section 4.4. However, the appositional structure for addressing women remains a stronghold of U-forms. (29) is an example of a creative use of the pattern. The noun *ekspert* is not normally used for direct address and has an established D-form *ekspertka*. However, in the given situation, the U-form was chosen as a way of semi-direct address.

- (29) T-o dla pan-i ekspert.
 this-NOM.SG for Mrs-GEN.SG expert[GEN.SG]
 ‘This is for [you,] expert.’ (NKJP)

(30–31) show words with relatively little prestige used as U-forms without the honorific. The examples are recent press headings which Szpyra-Kozłowska (2021) presents as instances of blatant overuse of the uninflected pattern.

- (30) polsk-a szpieg uhonorowan-a w Londyni-e
 Polish-NOM.SG.F spy[NOM.SG] honour.PTCP-NOM.SG.F in London-LOC.SG
 ‘A Polish [woman] spy [from WW2] honoured in London’
 (Szpyra-Kozłowska 2021: 339)
- (31) Piękn-a sołtys wyznaje.
 beautiful-NOM.SG.F village_leader[NOM.SG] confess.3SG
 ‘The beautiful village leader confesses.’ (339)

(30) features the use of *szpieg* as a U-form, although the concept is usually expressed as an M-form. For *sołtys* in (31) a more or less established D-form exists. The examples are certainly not typical for this word type and may seem questionable for some speakers. On the other hand, such examples of U-forms prove the pattern is productive.

In sum, the nouns preferring D-forms are very much regular: their form and inflection are in line with semantics. The ones preferring M-forms also inflect,

²⁶In the 20th century Polish linguists suggested various factors other than prestige as blocking the creation of D-forms, and promoting U-forms/M-forms in the lexicon, cf. Buttler et al. (1973: 108–110). Szpyra-Kozłowska (2021: 190–241) offers a convincing criticism of these factors, calling them “myths”. One of them is the identity of the feminine *-k(a)* and suffixes with other meanings, cf. fn. 25.

but ignoring the actual feminine reference. U-forms are exceptional because of their uninflectedness. As can be seen, they are not distributed freely in the lexicon, but concentrate in the domain of words for professions and professional titles. Despite these divisions in the lexicon, there is still a considerable field for competition between the three types.

3.3.4 Register

When they are in competition, U-forms are somewhat formal while the competing D-forms are informal and often colloquial. This matches the factor of prestige, cf. Section 3.3.3. Let us consider the word *dyrektor* ‘school principal’ as an example. Since many principals in Polish schools are women, it is naturally used as a U-form, typically with the honorific: *pani dyrektor*. This form is expected and used in contexts like teacher-student or teacher-parent communication, and esp. when addressing the principals. However, in less formal contexts, e.g. between students or between fellow teachers, the D-form *dyrektorka* is used as well. This pattern is found with many U-forms. It is generally easier for the U-forms to appear in less formal contexts, cf. (17) taken from an online forum, than for the D-forms to enter formal register.

As the official U-forms “trickle down” into less formal registers and contexts, this leads to partial semantic bleaching of the honorific *pani*. It may be retained in contexts where little or no marking of respect is needed or intended. The appositional structure with the word is simply the most certain way to assure clarity of the feminine reference. As a result, this polite word becomes an auxiliary noun, an analytic marker of the feminine gender and carrier of the inflectional marking, cf. the discussion of the data from Table 4.

(32) mentions a school principal, first giving the masculine noun (strictly speaking an M-form) and then correcting that the principal is actually a woman (with a U-form in apposition). The word *pani* is used to mark the gender rather than show respect. A plain U-form would feel inadequate, in line with the belief of the speakers that U-forms are “masculine”, cf. Section 3.1.

- (32) Mamy spoko dyrektor-a tzn. pani-ą dyrektor.
 have.1PL ok principal-ACC.SG i.e. Mrs-ACC.SG principal[ACC.SG]
 ‘We have a good principal, that is Ms principal.’ (NKJP)

The same effect can be observed in metalinguistic comments. The title of the article by Szpyra-Kozłowska (2019) quoted above presents various options for labelling a female prime minister: a D-form created by conversion (*premier-a*), a

D-form created by suffixation (*premier-k-a*) and a U-form. The last one is tellingly presented in apposition with the honorific.

Similarly, (12) above is a newspaper headline. The use of the D-form *ministra* was criticised in the comments on the newspaper's website. One of them provided the "nicer" alternative: *pani minister*. The actual headline with the D-form does not need a honorific and neither would a similar headline about a man.

3.3.5 Ideology

In recent years the competition of U-forms and D-forms has gained ideological overtones in the public discourse in Poland. Stępień (2018, after Szpyra-Kozłowska 2021: 158) shows that D-forms are more common in liberal and left-wing media than in right-wing ones. Particularly well publicised instances of use of individual D-forms spark heated debates, cf. Section 4.4. The divide can be seen in the Sejm as well. On several occasions female MPs requested their plaques and official items like voting cards bear the D-form label of their position: *posłanka* rather than U-form/M-form *poseł*.²⁷ Only left-wing MPs made such requests.

Word type choices can lead to arguments. Let us recall one such event from the Sejm. It is customary for MPs to start their speeches by addressing the person presiding over the session. In 2019, the MP Krzysztof Mieszkowski started his speech with the phrase *Pani Marszałkini*, thus using a D-form of *marszałek* 'speaker of the parliament'. The presiding deputy speaker Małgorzata Gosiewska immediately protested with passion and requested that a U-form be used when she is addressed.²⁸ The said MP came from the then liberal opposition and the deputy speaker is a member of the then ruling conservative party.

4 Historical development of U-forms

4.1 Background

In earlier stages of Polish a novel usage of a concept with reference to a woman rather than a man resulted in feminine derivation. Thus, D-forms dominated, both among common nouns and surnames. Interesting proofs of the strength of the pattern are the nouns *papieżyca* 'popess' (limited range of application),

²⁷<https://oko.press/kancelaria-sejmu-nie-zmienila-tabliczek-poslanki-sa-poslami>
Accessed 27.06.2024.

²⁸<https://wiadomosci.onet.pl/kraj/spiecie-w-sejmie-marszalek-gosiewska-ja-sobie-niezycze/thz3bdx> Accessed 23.06.2024.

szpiegini ‘spy, F’ or *gościni* ‘guest, F’ (both later supplanted by M-forms, cf. Section 3.3.3). However, M-forms (U-forms?)²⁹ were used too, not necessarily very seldom. Apparently, the oldest attested M-form in a text written in Polish comes from Mikołaj Rej, a 16th century writer (Nitsch 1951: 65).

Below we sketch the history of the development of U-forms and their competition with other types, but let us recall that changes affected only a relatively small part of the lexicon. Numerous common nouns have been D-forms for centuries, e.g. most of those in (27). Women’s surnames in *-sk(a)* have also been stable as D-forms. Such words are hardly mentioned in the following sections. Yet, the reader should bear in mind that they were present in the system and co-existed with the changing forms we focus on.

4.2 Surnames

As for surnames, D-forms were originally the norm and involved a differentiation between married and unmarried women, cf. Table 3. Women were identified by the relationship to their fathers or husbands and the possessive flavour to these forms may be felt by some speakers even today. The masculine variant was considered basic, a surname being a reflection of patrilineal ancestry. Hence, occasional mentions of women with this “true” form can also be found. These were probably U-forms from the very beginning.

Kucala (1978: 63) lists examples of female surnames from a 17th century diary, most of them are D-forms, but there are several U-forms as well. The practice of simplifying women’s surnames into U-forms gradually gained ground and allegedly was fashionable in the 18th century Warsaw (Nitsch 1951: 63). By the mid 19th century it became the subject of heated criticism by language purists, which is a proof of its spread. The criticism focused mostly on young women, esp. adolescent schoolgirls, who allegedly dared to use U-forms among themselves and with their female teachers. However, very similar complaints are attested from 1850s until 1900s (Pawłowski 1951: 50), which shows that U-forms and D-forms of surnames co-existed for decades in actual usage, most likely with register differences.

Another source of support for U-forms was foreign administration of partitioned Poland, which operated in German or Russian and did not use traditional Polish D-forms for surnames. The Austrian partition adopted Polish as the official language in the 1860s, but the use in documents in the following decades

²⁹In the case of historical, and esp. metalinguistic evidence, it is often difficult to distinguish these two.

varied (Kowalska 2013). The region seems to have clung to D-form surnames more than the other two partitions (Nitsch 1951: 63; Pawłowski 1951: 56).

After the First World War, the newly independent Poland introduced mandatory use of traditional, “patriotic” D-form versions of female surnames in documents (Dacewicz 2021). Actual practice varied and D-forms proved difficult in use. With some surnames they involved sound alternations, which could lead to mistakes in recreating the male versions from the D-forms. Consequently, in 1930 the Ministry for Education relaxed the regulations – in school documentation D-forms remained mandatory for surnames in *-wicz* (Pawłowski 1951: 54), otherwise U-forms were allowed. Let us also recall that with most surnames, D-forms revealed the marital status, which was certainly felt as a flaw of this structure by many women.

After the Second World War, U-forms were once again introduced as the default versions of women’s surnames in administration and official documents. Usage varied and the new standard was more eagerly used by younger people. In the early 1950s D-forms did not seem under threat in informal use (Nitsch 1951: 64), while actively used U-forms were typical of schools (Pawłowski 1951: 49). Pawłowski presents surveys conducted in secondary schools and among bank clerks. The data suggest differences in use based on gender and age. Young women (pupils, bank clerks, also teachers) generally preferred U-forms, while male pupils opted for traditional D-forms (Pawłowski 1951: 54–55). Interestingly, Pawłowski (1951: 49) suggests that women’s surnames could have the form identical to male versions in the nominative (i.e. in the documents), but inflect as D-forms otherwise. It is unclear whether such hybrid usage was common at the time. It may well be just a compromise proposal by the scholar disapproving of uninflectedness, but aware of its spread.

With time, U-forms gradually dominated. Kucała (1978) recounts several surveys of surnames in the press, which clearly show that D-forms were used less and less. In the mid 1970s, traditional D-forms constituted 24% of women’s surnames in press obituaries, 6% in a women’s magazine and were absent from a youth magazine (Kucała 1978: 68) reflecting the steady decline across generations. The prevalence of D-forms in speech was probably higher, but the pattern was clearly losing ground. This tendency has never been reversed³⁰ and today D-forms for surnames are mostly spoken and informal. Yet, even within this limited range, the suffix *-ow(a)* remains productive, cf. the informal *Clintonowa*

³⁰We should note a trend to use D-forms of surnames among women in artistic (maiden name versions) and scholarly (married versions) circles. The names of some authors cited here: Grzegorzyczkowa, Puzynina and Waszakowa represent the latter group. The fashion is now gone – the youngest followers of it were born in the 1960s.

‘Mrs. Clinton’ or *Merkelowa* ‘Mrs. Merkel’. When using such forms many speakers today apply the suffix *-ow(a)* regardless of the marital status of the women involved.³¹

4.3 Common nouns

The “original” situation presented in Section 4.1 seems to have been the case for common nouns for a long time. D-forms dominated, appearing in the vocabulary when needed, but there were instances of M-forms, esp. in the copular construction (the earliest known M-form in Rej’s writings, cf. Section 4.1, appears in such a context). Most likely there was some form of “division of labour” between the types (cf. Section 3.3.3) and a minority of personal nouns were typically M-forms.

The late 19th century saw an unprecedented rise of women professionals as various occupations, positions and study programmes at universities were gradually opened to them. These social changes continued in the 20th century. The language needed labels for women doctors, lawyers, officials, etc. and these were often called by means of U-forms/M-forms, which spurred criticism by language purists roughly since the 1880s (Język Polski 1933: 28). The commentaries were emotional and used harsh language, e.g. accusing women with professional titles of cowardly and fraudulently hiding their femininity (Poradnik Językowy 1911: 118), cf. also fn. 32.

Such metalinguistic criticisms and later linguistic papers (notably Klemensiewicz 1957) give the impression that the progressive female professionals rejected D-forms, while conservative purists (mostly men) advocated this traditional structure. As the use of U-forms/M-forms was more and more common over decades, the protests allegedly became weaker as these structures gained some level of reluctant acceptance still in the interwar period (Klemensiewicz 1957: 112–113).

This narrative seems to present a partial picture only. First of all, it is not a given that the criticisms by individual language purists and conservatives, however vocal, are in any way representative of broader social perception of the structures, let alone the usage at the time. We should also note that some language authorities were tolerant towards M-forms (Język Polski 1931a: 30–31). We have surviving metalinguistic evidence from the critics of M-forms/U-forms, but very little from the other side. Woźniak (2014) cites copiously from feminist press of the interwar period, showing that D-forms and M-forms (she quotes no U-forms) were both used. In fact, it was normal to see a mix of the types in a single text.

³¹This practice is parallel to the standard usage of surnames in Czech, where most surnames have a single D-form in *-ová* (or *-ská*).

Individual women may have had their preferences, but the women's movement as a whole did not advocate any of the word types. Klemensiewicz (1957: 103) recounts a 1929 census of teachers in which D-forms and U-forms/M-forms for various positions in the educational system appear in comparable numbers. This suggests that differences in register between the types were relatively slight. We know of no official policy of the Polish state with reference to labelling women professionals.

An alternative scenario is that the early decades of the 20th century were a time of a constant rise in the number of women to whom the new words could realistically apply. It is then likely that this meant that both D-forms and U-forms/M-forms were used more and more often, but only the latter growth was noticed and discussed at length. Having been in use for several decades, the new formations naturally gained some acceptance. Furthermore, even though D-forms had been well established as a pattern, each new word of the type needed to be accepted by the speakers, esp. because of the variety of feminine suffixes (Woźniak 2014: 298–300; Obrębska-Jabłońska 1949: 1).

The concept that was at the forefront of the changes in the language and the society was the figure of a woman doctor. Female medics were an increasingly common sight, had contact with many people and the position had the prestige earlier reserved for men. Apparently, most of them preferred the U-form/M-form *doktor*, the argument being that this is the right translation of the Latin title they had been given (Poradnik Językowy 1911: 118). The purist critics disapproved of the plain U-form,³² and even of the apposition with *pani*, today standard, well into the 1930s (Język Polski 1931b: 159).³³ Even though the vocal purists advocated the D-form alternative *doktorka*, which was in use, not all people concerned with language correctness agreed, thinking the form is either “depreciative” (Poradnik Językowy 1906: 55) or “not strictly grammatical” (Poradnik Językowy 1925a: 104).

We may conclude that U-forms/M-forms were becoming more common in the interwar period, but they did not gain acceptance of refined and traditional speakers. Alternative D-forms were not accepted straightforwardly either. The data

³²The editors of Poradnik Językowy (1925b: 15) described a sign advertising a medical practice of a dermatologist *dr I Krzywy*. The acronym stands for the word *doktor* and the surname is not a D-form so it was perfectly possible to conclude that the said medic is a man, which was not the case. The comment criticises the sign in a dramatic tone: what a misunderstanding it would be if a male patient decided to consult Dr. Krzywy!

³³Recounting his own stay in hospital, Benni (1933: 184) suggested a hybrid formation, the feminine honorific and an M-form: *z pani-q doktor-em* ‘with [Ms.] doctor’. Klemensiewicz (1957: 37) and Nitsch (1951: 65) present this structure as one in use in the interwar period and even later (cf. also Kupiszewski 1967: 374), but Benni’s own mention of the surprise of the nurses and a response from Obrębska (1933) suggest it was not particularly frequent.

from Klemensiewicz (1957) and Woźniak (2014) quoted above suggest the register variation between the types was not very strong at the time. Yet, the example of female doctors suggests the modern opposition of formal/polite U-form with the honorific vs. the informal D-form, as described in Section 3.3.4, was forming already.

The communist rule installed in Poland in 1945 brought important changes to society, including massive employment of women. Consequently, there were even more real-life situations when they could be referred to by their professions or addressed by professional titles. The field of competition between D-forms and U-forms/M-forms grew immensely. The official ideological position that men and women are equal translated into the use of exactly the same labels for both sexes in official language. In other words, M-forms/U-forms were promoted against “backward” D-forms. Plain U-forms started to appear in written texts other than official records (Obrębska-Jabłońska 1949: 3–4) and gained momentum. The move away from D-forms might have been modelled on Russian (Woźniak 2014: 305), but some see the development in Polish as independent (Łaziński 2006: 250). The use of different formations for common nouns referring to women varied in the early years after the war and so did the views of the speakers. We have surviving mentions of disagreements between speakers (e.g. Doroszewski 1951) and criticisms of uninflectedness.

Varying opinions were expressed by linguists of the time. Pawłowski (1951: 60, 62) and Nitsch (1951: 65) accept the lack of inflection only in the appositional phrase *pani doktor*, condemning similar use of other nouns and plain U-forms. Yet, we must conclude that such usage (today standard) was clearly present in the language if it was criticised. Taking an opposite “progressive” stance, Klemensiewicz (1957) announces U-forms/M-forms to be finally victorious in their long competition against D-forms among words for (prestigious) professions and professional titles. As we shall see below, his conclusions were definitely too hasty. The supposed triumph was also limited, as a considerable portion of the feminine lexicon had always been served by D-forms, cf. Section 3.3.3, and this remained so. A decade later, Kupiszewski (1967) also sees the use of M-forms/U-forms as a strong and unstoppable tendency. Interestingly, his paper is inspired by a letter from a radio listener who protested against the trend and insisted on using the “correct” D-forms.

Kučała’s (1978: 51–61) survey of noun usage in press obituaries and announcements provides numerous examples of both D-forms and M-forms (more often than U-forms). Kučala (1978: 61) notes also the use of plain U-forms, but considers them to be colloquial. By the 1970s the use of U-forms was accepted by prescriptivist works – at least for those words where D-forms had not become

established (Buttler et al. 1973: 111), although care was advised to avoid plain U-forms (Buttler et al. 1973: 116). Later prescriptivist works are still slightly more approving of U-forms (Jadacka 2006: 128–129).

4.4 Recent developments

After the overthrow of communism in 1989, the incipient feminist movement started advocating for D-forms instead of U-forms/M-forms among common nouns. For some time such usage was limited and perceived to a large extent as an ideological declaration (Łaziński 2006: 278). Gradually the “new” D-forms started to appear in public discourse and raise controversy among native speakers, by now used to the presence of U-forms. In recent years there were several occasions when the use of specific D-forms in public statements drew great attention and led to heated debates among native speakers. The particularly controversial words were e.g. *ministra* (vs. M *minister*), *powstanka* (vs. M *powstaniec* ‘insurgent’), *gościni* (vs. M *gość* ‘guest’) and *posłanka* (vs. M *poseł* ‘MP’, cf. Section 3.3.5).

We will focus on the controversy with the first word. In the early 2012, the then Minister for Sport, Joanna Mucha, declared in a television interview that she prefers to be addressed *Pani Ministro*, i.e. with a vocative of the D-form *ministra*, as in (12). This provoked a flood of criticism, even from fellow ministers, but there were also voices of approval. Within days after the interview, a well-known linguist talked of Ms. Mucha “raping the language”.³⁴ There are also at least two linguistic articles with Ms. Mucha’s name in the title (Bobrowski 2012, Waszakowa 2014), much more moderate in tone. Most critics disapproved of any D-form, others would have accepted one created by suffixation: *ministerka*, cf. the analysis of the title of Szpyra-Kozłowska (2019) in Section 3.3.4. The Council for the Polish Language, an authoritative body on matters of language correctness, felt compelled to issue a statement. Their position (RJP 2012) was moderate, acknowledging the possibility of conversions like *ministra* but voicing scepticism about their chances of being generally accepted.³⁵ They also mentioned numerous messages they had received and asserted that most women were sympathetic to Ms. Mucha’s D-form. One of the largest Polish dailies, *Gazeta Wyborcza*, uses

³⁴<https://www.wprost.pl/kraj/308115/ministro-mucho-nie-mozna-gwalcic-jezyka.html>
Accessed 28.06.2024

³⁵Interestingly, the verdict was perceived as a victory for the D-form, since it was not fully condemned, cf. a title of a press report stating simply that “*ministra* is correct” <https://www.newsweek.pl/polska/ministra-w-jezyku-polskim-jest-poprawna-rada-jezyka-polskiego/9b9q25g> Accessed 28.06.2024.

the word *ministra*, cf. (12). It seems this practice started after Ms. Mucha's interview.

Despite fervent opposition from purists and conservatives,³⁶ D-forms keep spreading in the public sphere. Occasionally, D-forms appear in official contexts as well, cf. the title of the dean of one of the faculties at Adam Mickiewicz University in Poznań: *dziekana* (vs. standard *m dziekan*),³⁷ or the title of the deputy mayor of Sopot: *wiceprezydentka* (vs. *m wiceprezydent*).³⁸

As can be seen, the pace of change is quick and the more often D-forms are used, the more acceptance they eventually gain. Paulina Mikula, a youtuber specialising in language and language correctness, made two videos concerning D-forms. In the later one (made in 2019), she is more approving and admits that she has changed her attitude, she "simply got used to" D-forms.³⁹ The earlier video was created only 5 years prior.⁴⁰

We must note that the current debate about D-forms completely ignores surnames, here the use of U-forms is not contested and no change in usage is detectable. Interestingly, both the dean from Poznań and the deputy mayor from Sopot mentioned above have surnames that are U-forms according to the current norm, *Pawelczyk* and *Jachim* respectively, and it is these forms that appear officially next to the innovative D-forms for their positions.

4.5 U-forms: the history of a category

U-forms appeared in Polish as an innovative pattern in those cases where the general tendency to create D-forms for feminine referents was overcome by the need to preserve the "true" form of the words in question, i.e. that identical to the masculine version. The resultant conflict of morphonology and semantics made most such formations uninflected, but not all: M-forms are attested today and were very likely more common than U-forms at early stages of the diversion from D-forms. As Sections 4.2 and 4.3 show, the development happened twice, first for some types of surnames (in the period from the 18th century until the second half of the 20th century) and then for common nouns denoting prestigious

³⁶Ironically, at least until the 1960s a conservative approach was to use and support D-forms rather than U-forms, cf. Section 4.3.

³⁷<https://anglistyka.amu.edu.pl/strona-glowna/wladze-wydzialu> Accessed 28.06.2024.

³⁸<https://trojmiasto.wyborcza.pl/trojmiasto/7,35612,28938409,magdalena-czarzynska-jachim-zastepczyni-prezydenta-sopotu.html> Accessed 28.06.2024.

³⁹<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TjJZ8THmtXQ> Accessed 28.06.2024.

⁴⁰https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VJZm2vAh_Oc Accessed 28.06.2024.

professions, positions and professional titles (in the period from the late 19th century until the second half of the 20th century). In the latter case an intermediate stage of M-forms is detectable in the first half of the 20th century.

The category of U-forms expanded in three ways: among speakers, in the lexicon and across linguistic contexts. The gradual spread in the population is presented in Sections 4.2 and 4.3. As for the lexical range of U-forms, it has always been limited, D-forms being the majority among lexical concepts with possible feminine reference. However, U-forms successfully dominated their niches in the lexicon and were eventually accepted by the speakers for these types of words (this happened roughly in the 1960s and 1970s), to the point that the newly (re)created D-forms are rejected by more conservative speakers at present. The acceptance for U-forms is still weak beyond their typical domains, cf. Szpyra-Kozłowska's (2021: 336–341) criticism of (30–31). Yet, attestations of such spread in the lexicon are a proof of the strength and continuing productivity of the pattern. As for the syntactic contexts, the appositional construction has always been a stronghold of U-forms. It is very likely that it was their original context (with given names for surnames and the honorific *pani* for common nouns). The construction remains a typical environment for U-forms, cf. Table 4.

Today U-forms are used freely in the singular (except for the copular construction), but are still limited in the plural. It is likely that the hierarchy of contexts for the use in the plural shown in Table 5 is also a historical development path of U-forms in general: from the “quoted” basic form in apposition to the fully independent use where the lack of inflection may be the sole marker of the feminine gender.⁴¹ This perspective allows us to look again at the status of U-forms in the lexicon. We may reconcile Łaziński's (2006: 227) argumentation against U-forms as separate lexemes and the counterexamples, cf. Section 3.3.2. The latter represent a more mature stage of the development which has not been reached (fully) by too many speakers yet. In the wake of the recent developments and the rebound of D-forms, U-forms may well retreat and never fully mature.

It is rather sure that U-form surnames and common nouns are facing different fates in the nearest future. The former are not threatened in any way while the latter might lose territory to D-forms. This is due to different attitudes and choices of the speakers regarding the two groups.

As for common nouns, we cannot tell whether the current increased use of D-forms will eventually overcome the practice of using U-forms or prove a tem-

⁴¹In the early 1950s, the use of the U-form *doktor* was accepted by conservative linguists (Pawłowski 1951: 65) in apposition with the honorific, the first context in Łaziński's hierarchy, but the use of a U-form with a feminine possessive, the next one, was novel and contestable (Doroszewski 1951: 32).

porary fashion. Most likely the coexistence of the types will remain for long, but it might be demarcated differently. To oust U-forms from their current contexts of use, D-forms would need to lose their ideological flavour so that they feel neutral (enough) for the majority of speakers.

5 Conclusions

The paper has presented how a productive uninflected pattern functions in Polish and how it arose in spite of the omnipresent inflection. Current usage shows symptoms of the difficulty posed by uninflected forms and repair mechanisms, chiefly apposition. The case of U-forms provides an interesting insight about the concept of systemic pressure. U-forms are exceptional in Polish grammar, but they were able to emerge as a class, spread and establish their position. The pressure of the system appears to have lain dormant for several decades as they became more and more common. The current (partial) retreat of U-forms is linked first of all to the awareness of speakers and their conscious choices.

A notable side effect of the existence of U-forms is the new function of the feminine honorific *pani*, which is regularly used in contexts where marking respect is not needed or intended. The word is then an auxiliary noun, carrying the inflection lacking on the U-form and marking the gender explicitly.

Our analysis also shows that Polish is rather tolerant to the coexistence of different patterns and subclasses of words. The situation established by the late 20th century involves standard use of U-forms for some surnames and some common words, while surnames in *-ska* and most common words referring to women remain D-forms. This kind of tolerance was also a necessary part of the emergence of U-forms. The above is linked to another observation: Polish easily allows productivity of minor inflectional patterns, which we have noted several times in Section 2. U-forms are only one example of this.

Another feature of Polish that surfaces in the analysis is the notion of the “basic form” of a noun. This status of the nominative singular is more than a convention applied by linguists and lexicographers; it seems to match the perception the speakers have. The desire to keep this “true” form of a word across all contexts (which may be triggered by a number of factors, cf. Section 2.2) is instrumental for uninflectedness, including the case of U-forms.

We may note the role of individual words in paving the way for whole categories in historical changes. It seems that the first successful and fully accepted U-form was the word *doktor*, cf. Section 4.3. Similarly, publicised controversies concerning few words have played a significant role in bringing D-forms back in

recent years, cf. Section 4.4. We can also assume that in the final decades of the 19th century, the presence of U-form surnames in the language helped the rise of uninflected common words referring to women.

Abbreviations

Less typical abbreviations used in the paper are:

IMPERS	impersonal	NVIR	non-virile
INAN	inanimate	PREP	preposition
NNOM	non-nominative	VIR	virile (masculine personal)

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